

End-of-Lease Bond-Back Checklist — Victoria

Protect your money — most bond disputes are avoidable with the right documentation.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal advice.

Section 1 — Understand How Your Bond Actually Works

- ☐ [] **Know that your bond is held by the RTBA, not your landlord or agent.** In Victoria, all residential bonds must be lodged with the **Residential Tenancies Bond Authority (RTBA)** — an independent government body. Your landlord or agent never holds your bond money directly.
- ☐ [] **Understand bond is not a general maintenance fund.** It can only be claimed against for specific things: unpaid rent, cleaning to return the property to its condition at the start of the tenancy (allowing for fair wear and tear), missing inclusions listed in the condition report, or agreed garden/lawn work left undone.
- ☐ [] **Know the fair wear and tear standard.** Normal deterioration — faded paint, minor carpet wear, small scuffs from ordinary living — is *not* something you can be charged for. Damage from neglect (stains, burns, mould you caused) is different and can be claimed against.

Section 2 — Before You Move Out

- ☐ [] **Locate your original entry condition report** — this is your baseline. If you don't have a copy, request one from your agent/landlord now.
- ☐ [] **Compare the property's current condition to that report**, room by room, and address anything that's genuinely beyond fair wear and tear.
- ☐ [] **Clean thoroughly** — note that under current Consumer Affairs Victoria guidance, professional cleaning isn't automatically required unless it was specified in your agreement or the property was professionally cleaned before you moved in; clean to a standard consistent with the condition report either way.
- ☐ [] **Check every item on the original inventory** is present and in working order (keys, remotes, appliances, fixtures listed in the condition report).
- ☐ [] **Complete any agreed garden/lawn maintenance** if this was your responsibility under the lease.
- ☐ [] **Settle any outstanding rent or approved fees** before vacating.

Section 3 — At the Final Inspection

- ☐ [] **Attend the final inspection in person if you can.** You and the landlord/agent should compare the property against the original condition report together.
- ☐ [] **Take your own timestamped photos** of every room after cleaning, even if you attend the inspection — this protects you if the agent isn't present or a dispute arises later.
- ☐ [] **Know the exit condition report timeline** — your rental provider or agent must complete the exit condition report within **10 days** of the tenancy ending.
- ☐ [] **Keep every receipt** — professional cleaning, carpet cleaning, pest control, repairs — as evidence of what you addressed.

Section 4 — Claiming Your Bond

- ☐ [] **You can lodge your bond refund claim directly with the RTBA** once you've vacated — you don't need to wait for the landlord to initiate this.
- ☐ [] **If there's no dispute**, both parties sign off and the RTBA pays your refund into your nominated bank account.
- ☐ [] **If the landlord disputes your claim**, they generally have **14 days** to lodge that dispute (through Rental Dispute Resolution Victoria, or historically directly to VCAT) — if they don't act within this window, you can ask for the dispute to be dismissed.
- ☐ [] **Don't agree to "cancel" your RTBA claim** to negotiate informally with the landlord — this removes a procedural protection you have under the Act. Insist on a written settlement first if you're negotiating outside the formal process.

Section 5 — If There's a Dispute

- ☐ [] **Try Rental Dispute Resolution Victoria (RDRV) first** — this free mediation service can often resolve bond and compensation disputes without needing a tribunal hearing.
- ☐ [] **If RDRV doesn't resolve it, you can apply to VCAT** — the Victorian Civil and Administrative Tribunal will review evidence from both sides and make a binding decision under the *Residential Tenancies Act 1997*.
- ☐ [] **Bring your entry and exit condition reports, timestamped photos, and all receipts** to any RDRV or VCAT hearing — documentation is what decides most bond disputes.
- ☐ [] **Know that compensation claims (as opposed to bond claims) have a much longer window** — landlords can apply for compensation for loss or damage up to 6 years after it occurred, so don't assume moving out closes the door on all possible claims.

Quick Reference — Bond Process Timeline

STEP	TIMEFRAME
Exit condition report completed	Within 10 days of tenancy ending
Landlord disputes a bond claim	Must act within 14 days or risk dismissal
RDRV mediation	Free, tried before VCAT in most cases
Compensation claims (separate from bond)	Landlord has up to 6 years to claim

